

Glossary

Adaptation

The way in which a living species has evolved its appearance or behavior, to fit in with its environment.

Alpine

Refers to something that lives or grows in mountainous areas.

Aquatic

Describes organisms that live in water.

Arctic Circle

The imaginary line that encircles the Arctic regions of Eurasia and North America.

Biome

A large area that has a particular climate, type of vegetation, and animals living in it.

Browse

Describes when animals feed on leaves and twigs from shrubs and trees, higher above ground.

Bycatch

Fish or other animals caught by mistake in nets laid out to catch other species.

Canopy

The topmost branches of the trees in a forest.

Carnivorous

Describes an animal that only eats meat.

Carrion

The remains of dead animals that scavengers feed on.

Cartilage

The tough, flexible material that makes up the skeleton of animals such as sharks.

Climate

The average weather conditions of an area over time.

Climate change

The process of gradual change to Earth's climate due to human activity.

Cold-blooded

Describes an animal whose body heat depends on the temperature of its surroundings, such as reptiles.

Colony

A group of animals—usually, but not always, of the same species—that live together.

Coniferous

A type of tree or shrub, such as pine, fir, or juniper, that has needles instead of leaves.

Conservation

The saving or protecting of animals or natural habitats.

Continent

One of the seven large landmasses on Earth: North America, South America, Europe, Africa, Asia, Australasia and Oceania, and Antarctica.

Continental shelf

The submerged edge of a continent that lies beneath shallow coastal seas.

Coral reef

A colony of corals growing in a rocklike formation on the seabed, home to a diverse range of marine life.

Crustacean

An animal with a hard external skeleton and paired, jointed legs, such as lobsters, crabs, and shrimp.

Deciduous

A type of tree, such as oak or birch, that loses leaves each year during a cold or dry season.

Deforestation

The cutting down of forests for timber or to clear land for farming or roads.

Delta

A low-lying, fan-shaped area at a river mouth, usually where the river flows into the sea.

Domesticated

Refers to an animal species that has been bred to be tamed and lives alongside people.

Echinoderm

One of a group of animals that includes spiny-skinned marine species, such as starfish and sea urchins.

Endemic

An animal or plant that is native to one specific area and found nowhere else.

Equator

An imaginary line, at 0° latitude, that divides Earth into the northern and southern hemispheres.

Estuary

The part of a river where it flows out into the sea, affected by tides.

Evolution

How animals and plants change over many generations as they survive and adapt.

Exoskeleton

The tough external skeleton of an animal such as an insect.

Extinct

Refers to an animal species that no longer exists because the last remaining individuals have died out.

Fertilization

The joining of male and female cells so they develop into seeds or a new organism. Also when dung or chemical fertilizers are spread on fields to make crops grow better.

Gills

The organ used by fish and other animals for breathing underwater.

Glands

Organs that produce hormones, or substances such as mucus, venom, or poison.

Habitat

The environment or place in which an animal normally lives.

Hemisphere

The northern hemisphere is the half of Earth north of the equator; the southern hemisphere is the half of the globe to the south of it.

Hibernation

When an animal hibernates, or goes into a deep, long sleep, to preserve energy during the cold season.

Incubate

To keep eggs warm so they can develop and hatch.

Intertidal zone

The part of the shore affected by tides. This area is covered by water when the tide comes in, and emerges when the tide goes out.

Invertebrate

An animal without a backbone, for example an insect, worm, or crustacean.